

back trailing two sets against South African Rik De Voest to deposit India into the Davis Cup World Group after 11 years.

Gautam Gambhir, 28, scored 1,828 runs and six centuries in the year (@ 90.87 in Tests, @40.38 in ODIs), but more than the statistics he radiated a fine balance of composure and boldness to become the most promising leader of his peer group.

Middleweight Vijender Singh, 24, Indian boxing's first-ever Olympic medalist, decided that he needed some more achievements and is now the first in the country to win a world championship medal. Flyweight Mayengbam Suranjoy Singh, 23, won gold and the title of best boxer in the President's Cup in Azerbaijan becoming one of boxing's two flame-throwers of the year.

Gaganjeet Bhullar, 21, brought Indian golf its good news of the year, as the sport worldwide focused only on a wounded Tiger. Not just the youngest from his country to win a title on the Asian Tour, he finished with five more on the Professional Golf Tour of India and the Asian leg

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MIDDLEWEIGHT VIJENDER SINGH, INDIAN BOXING'S FIRST-EVER OLYMPIC MEDALLIST,

is now also the first to win a world championship medal. Flyweight Mayengbam Suranjoy Singh won gold and the title of best boxer at the President's Cup in Azerbaijan and became one of boxing's two flame-throwers of the year.

**Vijender Singh (left);
Mayengbam
Suranjoy Singh**

qualifier for the British Open. There is every chance that Bhullar could soon become Kapurthala's best-known export, even more famous than the factory his father works for.

Barring Gambhir, all of them are solitary individuals, a prototype species in Indian sport. This is because its formal structure is less steel frame and more of a disintegrating skeleton. Unlike our giant neighbours whose sports factories churn out armies of athletes, Indian sports produces its revolutionaries, and in the decade slipping away, the Guevaras have increased in number, one year at a time.

Another posse is already tapping its feet: Yuki Bhambri won the Australian Open boys singles and made his Davis Cup debut, there is the magic of Guru Sai Dutt in badminton, the promise of Anirban Lahiri and Himmat Singh Rai to give Bhullar company, and the fists of Thokchom Nanao Singh, a world junior boxing champion.

If 2009 was the year of the revolutionaries who spurred revivals in their sport, the over-exposed, over-marketed, over-hyped world of cricket went back to its sober statesmen to give it real lustre in the title of the

world's No.1 Test team.

This has occurred because the seasoned centre of the squad decided, 18 months ago, that it could be done. It would take a fistful of Tests in the year—all of six—to cross the line. When it was, India they were without the captain who first set the idea out, Anil Kumble and the captain with whom India first began to go out and compete on tour, Sourav Ganguly.

But give thanks to cricket's gods, we still have the grand middle order trio of Sachin Tendulkar, Rahul Dravid and VVS Laxman and the one man who has changed all regulation for Test batsmen at large and

**All is
well
moments**

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